

Even the much-hyped Tesla Optimus, not expected to go into production until 2026, is gunning for a \$30,000+ price point (₹25.9 lakh). And Boston Dynamics' electric Atlas? Gorgeous moves, absurd price of \$100,000 (₹86.5 lakh), for research/industries, not for consumers until at least 2028.

Unitree's R1 is the first to break that mold, it's made for end users, priced for prosumer adoption (for now), and built with the flexibility to grow.

Life with a humanoid robot

Let's dream a little, and ask yourself –:what would you actually do with a humanoid robot at home? In your life?

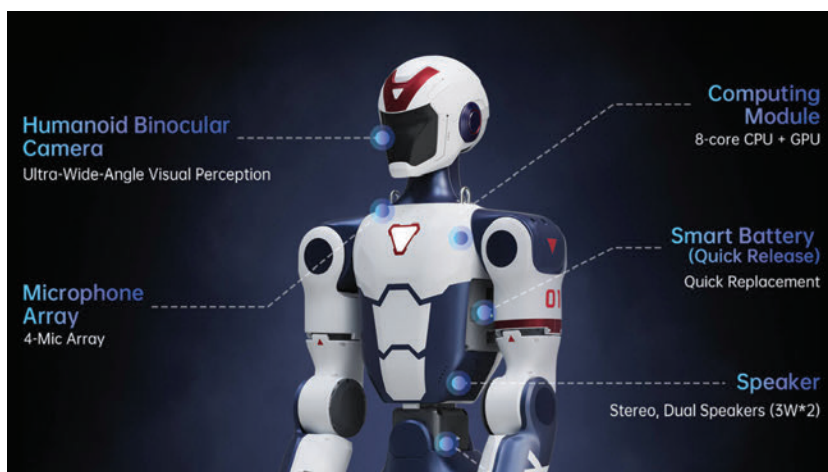
Imagine your morning routine. You wake up groggy, coffee not yet brewed. R1's already detected movement and started prepping your French press. It hands you your glasses, reads out your schedule, and reminds you of expected heavy rains in the evening. All of this with the fluid movement of something designed to live in human spaces, a bit like Rosey from The Jetsons (which I saw as a kid growing up in the '80s and '90s).

It could be your kid's homework buddy, answering geography questions while teaching a bit of coding on the side. It could help grandma fetch a medicine bottle from the top shelf. Or yes, let's indulge the fantasy – it could bust out a somersault when your friends come over, just to remind everyone that you live in the future.

But most importantly, it gives us a way to prototype and experiment with the ethics, etiquette, and expectations of sharing our spaces with intelligent machines. Because, I don't think the hardware is the hard part anymore – as Boston Dynamics, Tesla, and now Unitree have demonstrated. It's the culture that needs catching up. More than the humanoid robots adjusting to us, we need to adjust to them.

Not for everyone... yet

At ₹5.1 lakh in India (assuming import and taxes allow it in at all), this isn't mass-market, of course. It's a bold



experiment targeted at researchers, developers, and early adopters. The use case today isn't flipping burgers or babysitting toddlers – it's largely about affordable exploration.

But let's not understate the leap this represents. Compared to previous humanoid robots that cost north of \$20,000 – or \$100,000 in the case of Atlas – the R1 is a price disruption akin to when Xiaomi launched the ₹9,999 Redmi and suddenly smartphones weren't a luxury anymore.

Unitree is taking a loss-leader approach to democratize robotics. And whether the company nails the product roadmap or not, it's definitely lit a spark. Once people have real robots in their apartments and dorm rooms – not just Roombas or smart speakers, but bipedal companions with actual arms and eyes and semi-personality – we'll start building a new

layer of digital-human interaction. It's one thing to talk about the "embodied AI revolution" in theory. It's another to have it bring you your morning coffee while you're still in bed.

Ultimately, what excites me most about the R1 isn't what it can do right now, but how it makes me imagine the possibilities. Not careless flights of fancy, but real, grounded workflows. Of course, the Unitree R1 is far from perfect. It's not folding your laundry just yet, and it's unlikely to recite Gandalf's monologues from Tolkien's books. But it's real. You can order one. And that alone is a significant cultural threshold we just crossed.

I'm not saying everyone needs one today. I'm just saying that for the first time it's not crazy to start thinking about where the robot should sleep. Standing straight, to save space. Near the router, probably. Better Wi-Fi. **d**